



1264–1244 BCE

RAMESSES II EXPANDS EGYPT

Under pharaoh Ramses II, the Egyptian Empire extended southwards into gold-rich Nubia. As well as subjugating the Nubian people, Ramses II instigated a huge construction project in his Nubian territory as a lasting symbol of Egyptian power. This took the form of two massive temples cut into the rock at Abu Simbel, with giant relief figures carved into their facades: the Great Temple dedicated to Ramses himself; and the Small Temple to his chief wife Nefertari.

< Ramses II depicted in a temple relief

c. 1200 BCE The kingdom of Lydia is established in Asia Minor after the decline of the Hittite empire

c. 1100–800 BCE The Greek Dark Ages begin after the fall of the Mycenaeans

1000 BCE

c. 1200 BCE Chavin culture emerges in the Peruvian Andes

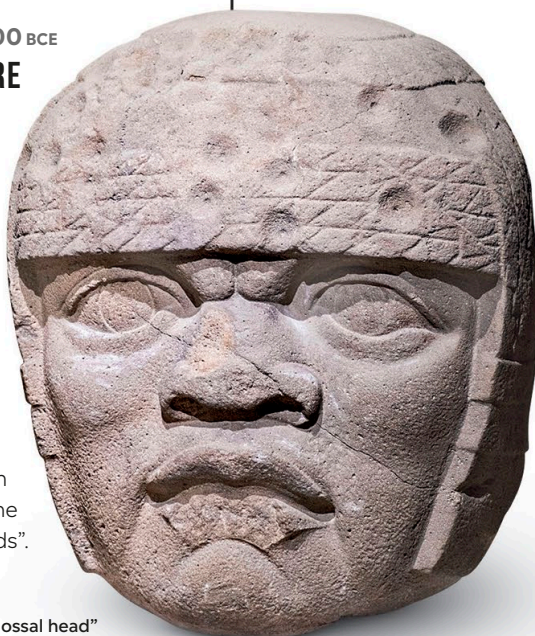
c. 1100 BCE The seagoing Phoenicians rise to become a major Mediterranean power

1046 BCE The Zhou Dynasty conquers the ruling Shang Dynasty in China

c. 1200 BCE

OLMEC CULTURE

The earliest known civilization in Mesoamerica, the Olmec culture, developed from settlements in the Gulf region of Mexico, having its centre first in San Lorenzo and later at La Venta. A prominent feature of the Olmec culture was its stone carving. As well as carved masks and axe heads presumed to be for ritual use, the Olmecs produced a number of massive sculptures in volcanic basalt, known as the “colossal heads”.



▷ Olmec “colossal head”

The Phoenicians’ most important trading commodity was purple dye obtained from the murex sea snail